

In the “Glorious Revolution,” William of Orange and his wife, Mary, accept the English throne and agree to a **Bill of Rights**.



1688–1689

The principle of **authors' copyright** is enshrined in UK law in the Statute of Anne.



1710

William Blackstone's *Commentaries on the Laws of England* lays out **English common law** in a comprehensive and accessible form.



1765–1769

In France, the Declaration of the Rights of Man and of the Citizen sets down the principle that **all people are equal under the law**.



1789

1692



More than 200 people are **accused of witchcraft** and 19 condemned to death on spurious evidence at the Salem witch trials in Massachusetts.

1758



In *The Law of Nations*, Emmerich de Vattel lays the foundations for **countries to cooperate under international law**.

1787



Delegates meet in Philadelphia to frame the **Constitution of the United States**, ratified by all states by 1790.

1791



Ten amendments, collectively known as the **Bill of Rights**, are added to the US Constitution.

of the Americas, slaves were transported from Africa in their hundreds of thousands, a practice given legal justification in the West Indian and American slave codes, which treated slaves as “chattel”—the property of their owners.

Reason above faith

Europe's new prosperity fostered intellectual and scientific inquiry, leading, in the late 17th and 18th centuries, to the Enlightenment, or “Age of Reason.” The Catholic Church still wielded considerable power, which it exercised in trying to quash “heretics” such as Galileo Galilei for their scientific theories. Its authority, however, was severely undermined, as was the notion of the divine right of kings and a monarch's authority over the people. Enlightenment theorists

promoted rational thought over religious faith, and progress, liberty, and tolerance over the old political order's deference to Church and monarchy, instead advocating constitutional government to protect the rights of citizens.

The first signs of this movement appeared during the English Civil War (1642–1651), with the trial and execution in 1649 of King Charles I and the subsequent establishment of the Commonwealth. In 1689, the introduction of a Bill of Rights as the English Parliament's condition for accepting the rule of King William and Queen Mary then confirmed the power of the law over the supremacy of the monarchy.

Inspired by the changes in the political order, English philosopher John Locke argued for a government that protects the

liberty and rights of its citizens. This cause was readily taken up elsewhere, including in the American colonies, which were growing resentful of their British rulers and sought independence under a more democratic and fairer government.

When America declared its independence in 1776, it asserted the rights of all men to life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness. This establishment of the concept of rights as central to the code of law was then embodied in the 1787 Constitution of the United States of America. France similarly overthrew its oppressive rulers in 1789, to install a government by the people and for the people, with its ideals of *liberté, égalité*, and *fraternité* embodied in the Declaration of the Rights of Man and of the Citizen. ■